

# Flu FEARS

As the swine flu virus spreads in India, concerns grow about the Government's ability to contain an epidemic

Outside Ram Manohar Lohia Hospital (RML) in Delhi, a lone man in a mask walks around a bend. Is the official nodal point for swine flu on such a war footing? Inside, you expect a flurry of people in masks and rubber gloves. But the humdrum of a big-city hospital takes you by surprise. "There's hardly any room for anxiety," says young intern Navnita Unnikrishnan. Apart from the isolation ward and occasional seminars on swine flu for doctors, it's business almost as usual at RML.

Don't panic, says the health fraternity, even as 74 countries report 29,699 laboratory-confirmed cases of influenza A/H1N1 and 145 deaths. But swine flu is no longer a mystery disease happening to "others". It's here in India too—from Delhi to Hyderabad, Jalandhar to Goa—with the numbers touching 35 on June 17. With 95 per cent of the cases detected among those coming from abroad, the health minister has restated the World Health Organization (WHO)'s advice on deferring non-essential travel abroad. At the same time, 21 international airports are being proactively guarded by 221 doctors and 111 paramedics. At chosen government hospitals, staffers experienced in handling chest syndromes and isolation wards are being kitted out with Personal Protection Equipment kits (gowns, three-layered N-95 masks, headgear, eye protection, boots, gloves and antivirals). "In such a situation, we should show concern, not panic," says Dr N.K. Chaturvedi, medical superintendent, RML. "H1N1 has proved self-limiting. There have been no complications so far."

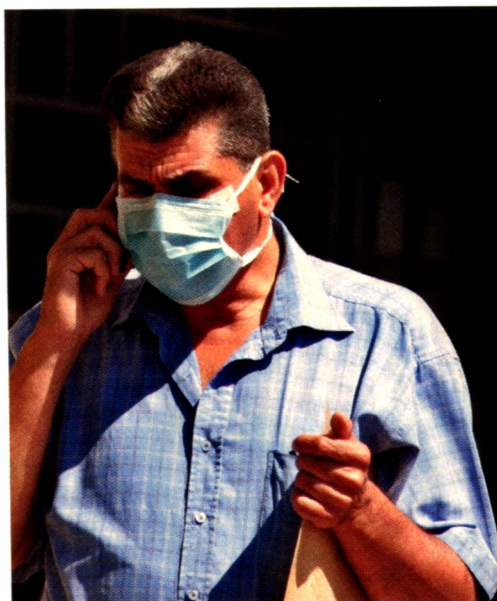
"Check out our website, [mohsw.nic.in](http://mohsw.nic.in) for updated information," says Dr Swasti Charan, expert

on community and emergency medicine, attached to the Health Ministry. While much remains unknown, here's what the medical fraternity knows for sure: that this strain of swine flu is spreading from human to human; symptoms include high fever, cough, sore throat, muscle aches,

nose or mouth (ordinary face masks don't provide protection).

So is the panic that the world, and India, could be on the brink of the first influenza pandemic in more than 40 years, needless? With its alert button pressed at phase 5, the WHO says, no. "The reaction primed the world to fight back what could have been a deadly disaster," says Dr Bir Singh, head of Community Medicine at the AIIMS, Delhi. "It's still not clear if the danger has passed, or is the virus mutating to strike back." The virus has so far shown about 0.5 per cent mortality. What if it becomes drug-resistant? Even if makers start brewing

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## The Toll So FAR...

Thirty five confirmed cases in India as on June 17, but no complications or deaths.

332 health workers at 21 airports have screened over 45,000 passengers.

India has a stock of 10 million capsules of Oseltamivir or Tamiflu.

If one person infects two in three days, containment may be difficult but possible.

## MORTALITY FIGURES ARE LOW, BUT MAY RISE IF THE VIRUS BECOMES DRUG-RESISTANT.

vomiting and diarrhoea; the drugs Tamiflu and Relenza have been effective in treating those with H1N1; the incubation time is one to three days, and infected people are ill for two to four days; the treatment is most effective if done within 48 hours of exposure; medication needs to be taken within 48 hours of the appearance of symptoms. Doctors suggest frequent hand-washing; covering your nose and mouth when you cough or sneeze; avoiding touching your eyes,

vaccine doses, it will take months to test immunity and safety. Nearly 70 per cent of India's healthcare is run by the private sector. In case of a major outbreak, will the Government's policy of restricting care to its hospitals work? Unanswered questions fly about. But seasonal flu time is round the corner. Citizens would do well to keep themselves informed and take precautions to limit potential exposure to this new infectious strain.

by Damayanti Datta